

7.62DT machine-gun
The T-34 tank was fitted with two 7.62DT machine-guns. One, which was static, used tracer rounds to guide the main turret gun.

for both the men and their machines, they covered the distance in three days and arrived exhausted but in good order at the battlefield. On the morning of 11 July some 850 Soviet and 600 German tanks advanced to attack one another, clashing in an area measuring around 7.5 sq km (3 sq miles). A German officer described the T-34s as "streaming like rats all over the battlefield." Outgunned by the German Tigers and Panthers, the Soviet tanks aimed to drive close in to their enemies, so their lighter guns would have maximum effect. Soon the tank forces were so intermingled that neither side could use its artillery or ground-attack aircraft. The fighting lasted for eight hours, a colossal armoured mêlée conducted amid intermittent thunder storms. The T-34 crews fought without a thought for survival. Tanks that had lost tracks or wheels went on firing until destroyed by enemy shells, exploding in flames, their turrets spinning through the air. When they ran out of ammunition, commanders deliberately rammed their vehicle into an enemy tank, so they could "take one with them". As many as 700 tanks may have been destroyed by the end of the day, more of them Soviet than German. The Soviets could cope with the scale of the losses, however; the Germans could not.

COSTLY VICTORY

The long advance of the Red Army from Kursk in July 1943 to the streets of Berlin in April 1945 was never easy and cost heavy casualties, though far fewer than in the battles of 1941–42. The readiness of the Soviet tank crews, like all other Red Army soldiers, to endure almost unimaginable losses and hardship was in the end the key to their victory. In a sense they were given no choice. Discipline in the Red Army was ferocious, enforced by the Stalinist political police, the NKVD. Any soldier or officer deemed to have shown cowardice or failed to execute orders to the letter would either be shot immediately or placed in a punishment battalion – almost equal to a death sentence, since such battalions were given tasks such as marching across minefields to clear a path for soldiers behind them. Yet there is no question that most Red Army soldiers were genuinely motivated to fight – by patriotism, by hatred of the invaders and their atrocities, and also in some cases by enthusiasm for the Soviet revolution.

> "ONE WOULD THINK WE WERE ON AN ISLAND IN A SEA OF FIRE. IT WAS SENSELESS TO STAY ANY LONGER."
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> **LIEUTENANT-GENERAL DRAGUNSKY** DESCRIBING THE BATTLE OF KURSK, 8 JULY, 1943

Tank column
A column of T-34 tanks moves west during the long offensive that began at Stalingrad, in the Caucasus, and ended in Berlin.

